

# Akanksha Vardani

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Last updated: December 28, 2025

## EDUCATION

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| <b>Columbia University, New York</b> – PhD in Economics                               | 2025 |
| – MPhil in Economics                                                                  | 2022 |
| – MA in Economics                                                                     | 2021 |
| <b>Delhi School of Economics, New Delhi</b> – MA in Economics                         | 2018 |
| <b>Indraprastha College for Women, University of Delhi</b> – BA (Honors) in Economics | 2016 |

## EMPLOYMENT

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| <b>Research Advisor</b> , Behavioural Insights Team | 2025- |
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## RESEARCH

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### **A House for Two: Empowering Women with Property Rights**

- Conducted RCT with 3500+ individuals in rural India to study property rights' impact women's empowerment.
- Collaborated with government administrative unit Pune Zilla Parishad and NGO [Chaitanya](#).
- Presentations: European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting (2024), Imperial College PhD Conference (2024), NBER Summer Institute (2023), Coverage: [BBC](#), [Sakal Newspaper](#)

### **How do political connections affect property tax compliance?** with [A. Parvathaneni](#).

- Used novel administrative property tax data over 550,000+ properties to study how political connections influence tax compliance.
- Collaborated with government administrative unit Pune Zilla Parishad.

### **Unpacking Willingness to Pay as a Measure of Women's Empowerment** with [A. Donald](#) and [B. Kramer](#).

- Use survey data from India and Rwanda to evaluate how complex lab-in-the-field (LIF) experiments compare with simple survey-based measures in measuring women's empowerment.

### **Community and Household Networks and Women's Workforce Entry** with [T. Kundu](#).

- Design and implement a field experiment to study the role of community networks in bridging the gap between women's skill training and labour force participation.
- In collaboration with NGO [Calcutta Foundation](#).

### **Signaling in Female Education** with [T. Kundu](#).

- Use data from IHDS and DHS to study the role of labor market and marriage market considerations in motivating investment in female education In India and Zambia.

### **Gender Bias and Gendered Outcomes: Some Pitfalls of Inference** with [B. Isaac](#) and [R. Somanathan](#).

- Combines theoretical models with secondary data to study the relationship between child sex-ratios and cost of accessing medical care.
- Presentations: 4th Annual Center for research on the Economics of Climate, Food, Energy and Environment (CECFEE) Research and Policy Workshop (2018), 14th Annual Conference on Economic Growth and Development (2018)

## WORK EXPERIENCE

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### *Field work*

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| Independently running a RCT in India with 3500+ individuals across 53 villages.                | May 2023-present |
| Conducted a household-level survey across 30 villages, covering 150 households in Pune, India. | October 2022     |
| Survey of workers of the informal wire stripping industry in Seelampur, Delhi.                 | March 2015       |
| Survey of workers of the informal garment sector in Kapashera, Delhi.                          | December 2013    |

*Research Assistant* – Michael Best and Evan Sadler, Department of Economics, Columbia University, New York. 2020-2021  
 Worked on a project that addresses the challenge of creating an efficient and equitable tax system by combining theory and randomized controlled trials (RCTs) in Paraguay.

*Research Assistant* – Rohini Somanathan, Department of Economics, Delhi School of Economics, New Delhi. 2017-2019  
 Worked on a project on caste and inequality in India. The project involved cleaning, handling and analyzing data from India Census from 1872 to 1941 using STATA and R along with writing regular reports.

*Research Analyst Intern* – India Institute, New Delhi 2015  
 Worked on two projects: (i) 'Higher Education Governance in India: A case study of Andhra Pradesh' which studied the role of politicians in governance of higher education institutions (ii) 'Primary Education: Private v/s Government School' which does a comparative analysis of education outcomes for a private and government school in Okhla.

*Research Intern* – Consumers India, New Delhi 2014-2015  
 Co-authored a report on 'Do Laws in India Promote Samaritan Behaviour?' that attempts to explain the deficit in Samaritan behaviour seen on Indian roads. A primary survey of over 150 people and interviews with domain experts were conducted to assess people's willingness, abilities and hindrances faced in helping victims.

## AWARDS, HONORS AND GRANTS

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| NBER Gender in the Economy Fellowship                                                 | 2023-2024 |
| SurveyCTO Primary Data Collection Research Grant (Honorable Mention)                  | 2024      |
| Wueller Pre-Dissertation Award for Best 4th-year Proposal, Columbia University        | 2023      |
| Reubens Travel and Research Award, Columbia University                                | 2023      |
| Wueller Award for Best TA for MA Program, Columbia University                         | 2022      |
| Wueller Award for Best TA (Runners up) for Undergraduate Courses, Columbia University | 2022      |
| Exim Bank Scholarship, DSE                                                            | 2016-2018 |
| National (CAS) Scholarship Internal, DSE                                              | 2016-2018 |
| Rai Bahadur Raghunath Sahai Memorial Prize, IPCW                                      | 2016      |
| Rewa Dhawan Memorial Scholarship, IPCW                                                | 2013-2016 |
| Nagendra Nath Majumdar Memorial Prize, IPCW                                           | 2016      |
| Principal's Honour Roll, IPCW                                                         | 2015      |

## RESEARCH GRANTS

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|---------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| <b>Weiss Fund</b> (with Aneesha Parvathaneni)                 | 2024 |
| <b>CDEP Student Research Grant</b> , Columbia University      | 2023 |
| <b>PER Experiment Grant</b> , Columbia University             | 2023 |
| <b>CDEP Student Research Grant</b> , Columbia University      | 2022 |
| <b>PER Experiment Grant</b> , Columbia University             | 2022 |
| <b>PER Research Fellow Summer Grant</b> , Columbia University | 2020 |

## OTHER

**Skills** STATA, R, Python, SurveyCTO, L<sup>A</sup>T<sub>E</sub>X, Microsoft Office.

**Languages** English (fluent), Hindi (native), French (intermediate), German (beginner).

## REFERENCES

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| <b>Cristian Pop-Eleches</b><br><a href="mailto:cp2124@columbia.edu">cp2124@columbia.edu</a> | <b>Michael Best</b><br><a href="mailto:mcb2270@columbia.edu">mcb2270@columbia.edu</a> | <b>Pierre-André Chiappori</b><br><a href="mailto:pc2167@columbia.edu">pc2167@columbia.edu</a> | <b>Bernard Salanié</b><br><a href="mailto:bs2237@columbia.edu">bs2237@columbia.edu</a> | <b>Jack Willis</b><br><a href="mailto:jw3634@columbia.edu">jw3634@columbia.edu</a> |
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